

A Blueprint for AI-Ready Schools: Strategies from the Front Lines of K–12 Education



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Introduction

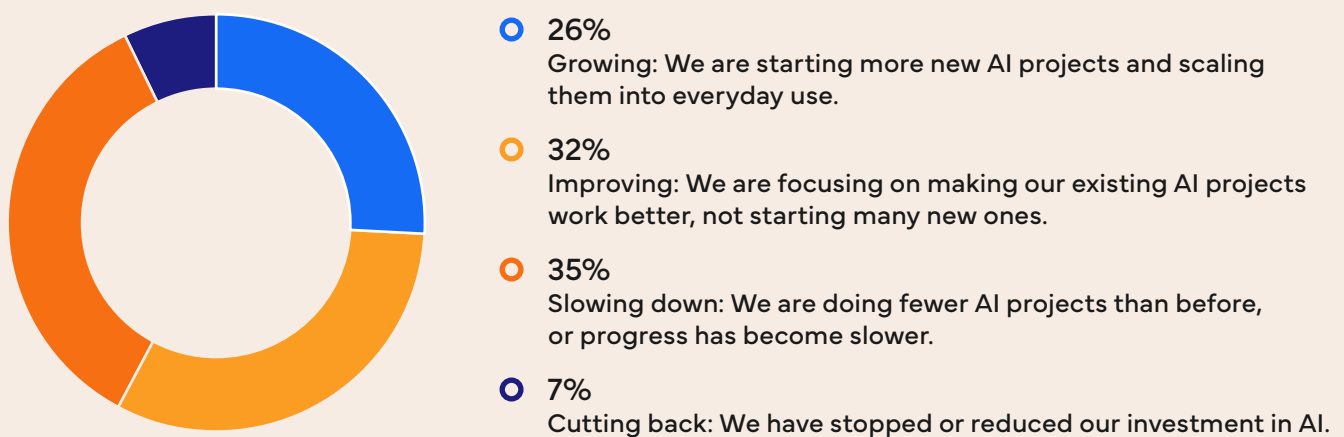
The emergence of ChatGPT in November 2022 set off a firestorm in K–12 education worldwide, with districts initially banning the tool from school devices and networks in early 2023, only to reverse course months later as the inevitability of AI adoption became clear.

Schools have shifted from reactive bans to strategic embrace, recognizing that AI is here to stay. This has forced education leaders to move from asking whether to adopt to asking how to adopt responsibly to best support students, faculty, staff, and families. In fact, schools around the world have made significant progress in their AI journeys over the last year, with 58% of education respondents in IDC's *Future Enterprise Resiliency Survey Wave 7* from August 2025 noting that their AI programs have grown (26.4%) or have improved (31.6%) over the last 12 months (**Figure 1, below**).

Figure 1

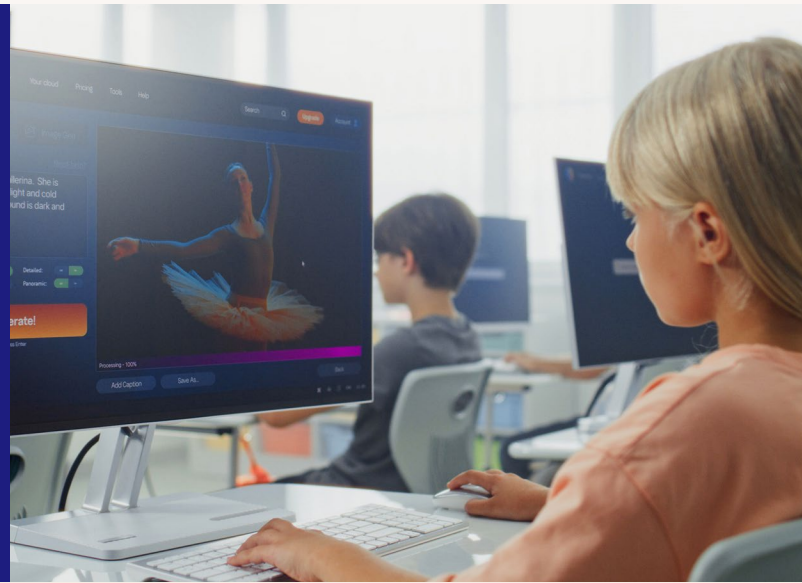
Current state of AI programs in K–12 education worldwide

Which of the following statements best reflects how your organization's AI program has changed in the past 12 months?



Source: IDC's *Future Enterprise Resiliency Survey Wave 7*, August 2025

Primary and secondary education is undergoing AI-driven change at an unprecedented pace, and several advanced schools around the world are leading the way and providing a blueprint for others to follow.



Moving forward, K–12 leaders see transformative opportunities with AI to address critical workforce challenges and enhance learning outcomes, including combating teacher shortages and burnout, improving operational efficiencies, enhancing parent–student–teacher communication, enabling hyper-personalized learning, and boosting both student academic performance and well-being.

However, although AI adoption continues to grow in education, significant challenges persist, particularly around academic integrity and plagiarism concerns, student data privacy and security, a lack of formal training, and uncertainty about governance frameworks and responsible use policies. As schools and districts assess their AI strategies and investments for 2026, the industry remains deeply committed to addressing these challenges and setting the example for responsible AI adoption.

Lessons learned from early AI adopters in K–12

Leading institutions globally have moved beyond pilot programs to strategic implementation at scale, achieving measurable results in reducing teacher workloads, improving student academic outcomes, and boosting student well-being. Primary and secondary education is undergoing AI-driven change at an unprecedented pace, and several advanced schools around the world are leading the way and providing a blueprint for others to follow.

Informed by qualitative interviews with IT and academic leaders, IDC conducted this research to understand the commonalities in approaches across three forward-looking schools around the globe: Brisbane Catholic Education (BCE) (Australia), Broward County Public Schools (United States), and Coquitlam School District (Canada).

In this white paper

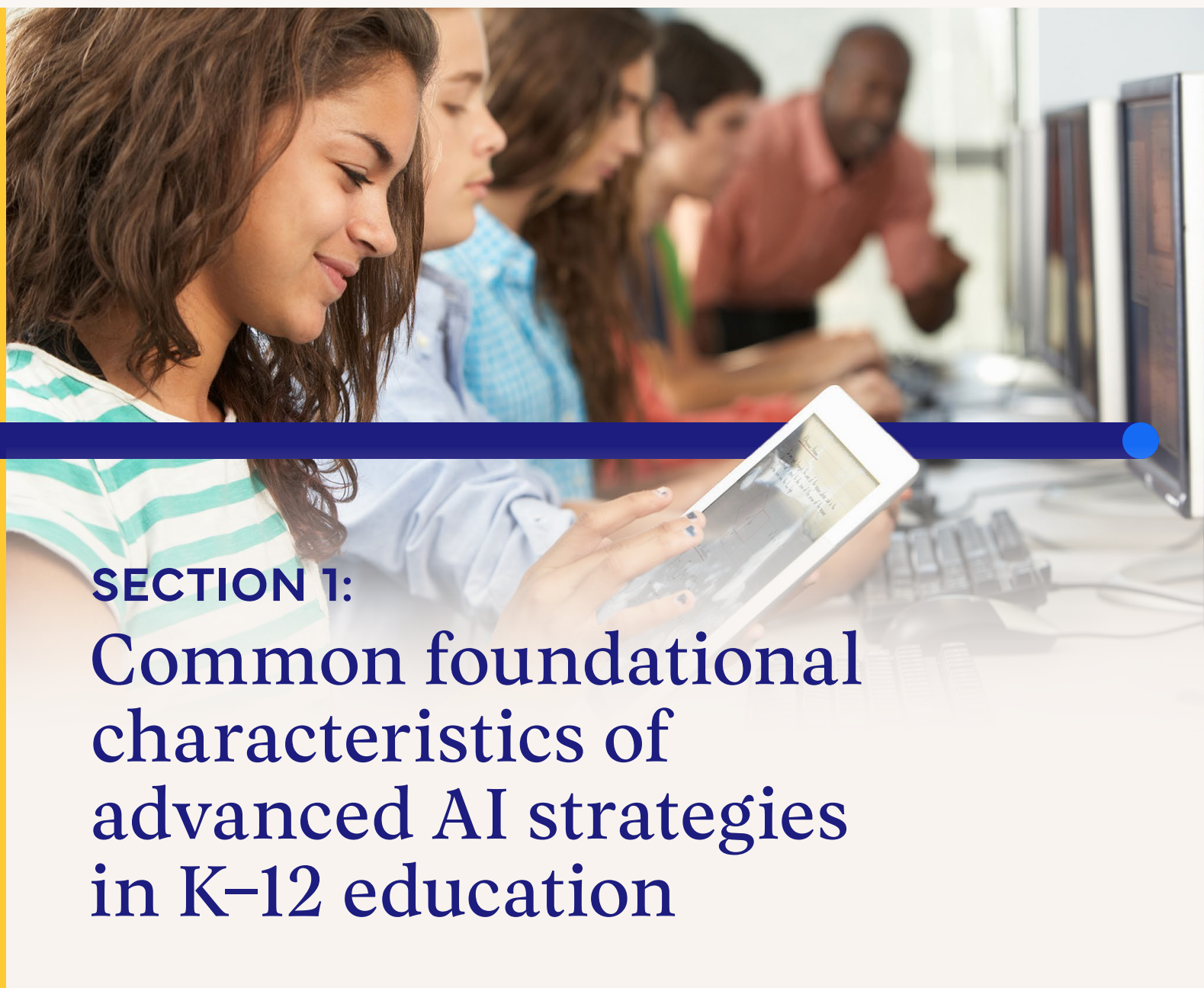
This white paper provides guidance and support for primary, secondary, and K–12 education leaders seeking to embark on a similar journey. By examining the best practices and strategies that the interviewed AI leaders employed, we aim to offer valuable insights and recommendations that can help institutions navigate the complexities of AI adoption and achieve their strategic goals.

Section 1:

The six common foundational characteristics of a strong AI strategy in primary, secondary, and K–12 education, as reflected in the practices of the schools and districts mentioned earlier

Section 2:

A series of strategic, organizational, pedagogical, process, and technology considerations for industry leaders as they execute their AI strategies



SECTION 1:

Common foundational characteristics of advanced AI strategies in K-12 education

Six common foundational characteristics define the AI strategies of the three schools and districts that IDC interviewed for this study.

1. Functional area focus

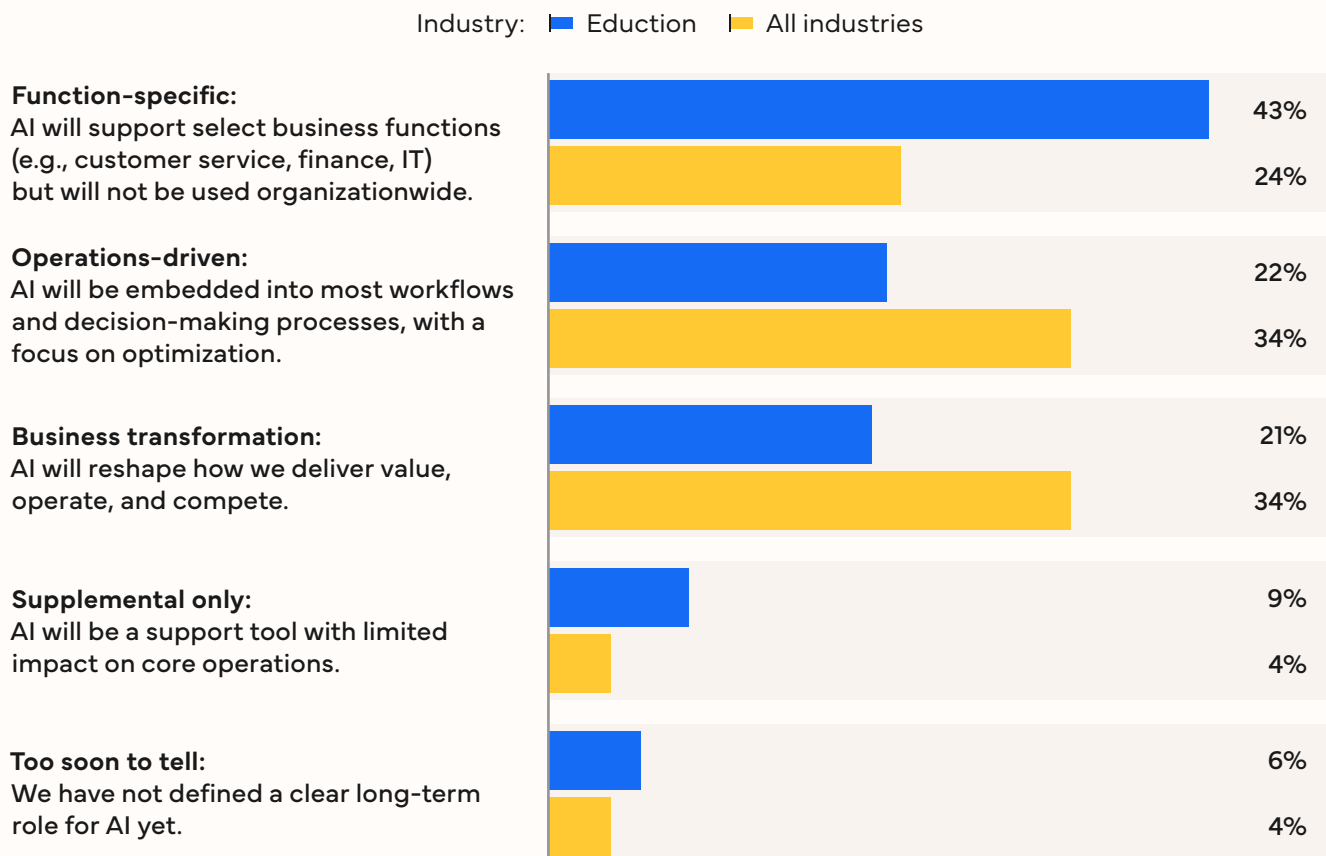
Schools are prioritizing significant AI investments in high-value, high-impact strategic functional areas (e.g., teaching and learning, administration and operations, student and family engagement). In fact, when IDC asked respondents whether their institutions focused

on business transformation (e.g., transforming service delivery), operations improvement (e.g., business process automation and optimization), functional area enhancements (e.g., enhanced select departmental functions), or supplemental capabilities (e.g., using AI for ad hoc support), the largest share of education respondents (43%) noted that they focus on functional area investments, nearly twice as much compared to respondents in other industries (23%) (**Figure 2, below**).

Figure 2**K–12 AI adoption focus**

Looking ahead several years, which of the following best describes the most important role that AI will play in your organization?

See the figure data in an [accessible table format](#).



Source: IDC's *Future Enterprise Resiliency Survey Wave 7*, August 2025



Case studies

- **Broward County Public Schools**

Board direction set a “Broward powered by AI” mandate that explicitly ties AI to core academic goals (such as boosting English language arts, algebra, and science proficiency while accelerating college and career readiness) and also targets operational efficiencies such as energy optimization (e.g., leveraging AI to monitor space utilization and control energy consumption in unused classrooms) and overtime reduction.

- **Coquitlam School District**

The district pursued a dual track in operations and learning, investing in a unified AI-ready data fabric and agentic bots for communication while rolling out Copilot to teachers to accelerate instructional planning. Emphasis on safety/security and student-facing supports (Copilot Chat) ensured value in both administrative productivity and classroom personalization.

2. Guardrails

Schools are implementing comprehensive governance frameworks and usage guidelines to ensure safe, ethical, and responsible AI use for faculty, staff, parents, and students.



Case study

- **Brisbane Catholic Education**

Guided by the Rome Call for AI Ethics framework, staff underwent mandatory ethics training before licensing, with governance covering legal, technical, change management, and user needs. Academic integrity guardrails include a maturity matrix clarifying when AI is prohibited, when staff can use it for planning only or writing assistance, and when staff are permitted to use it for feedback.

3. Learning communities

Schools are creating open community groups and multimodal communication channels for networks of faculty, staff, families, and students to share best practices and lessons learned, maintain open lines of communication, and provide greater transparency and collaboration in AI use.



Case studies

- **Brisbane Catholic Education**

The school implemented cross-functional professional learning communities, lunch-and-learns, and communication channels monitored for rapid support, which turned staff success stories into momentum. The Creative AI Lab, which an ideation agent (“Sparky”) supports, provides a shared space to propose, refine, and scale promising AI use cases across schools.

- **Coquitlam School District**

The district operates a broad educational technology committee, including teachers, administrators, parents, and district leadership, to openly share practices and codesign direction. Classroom exemplars, collaboration through a pedagogical help desk, and monitored channels help educators share issues and pursue best practices to spread what works across schools.

4. Change management and training

Schools are providing continuous, role-specific professional learning and training that meets faculty, staff, families, and students where they are with technical skill level and age-appropriate content. Additionally, there is a direct and intentional effort to dispel myths and address ethical and responsible use concerns among all stakeholder groups, particularly teachers and parents who are concerned about AI’s emerging role in the classroom.



Case study

- **Broward County Public Schools**

The district implemented mandatory AI training for principals and assistant principals, developed micro-credentialing aligned with ISTE/state standards, and tiered professional learning programming combining district-curated and vendor-led sessions. The district provides continuous professional learning for faculty, embedded coaching, and a school-based AI liaison to mitigate the implementation dip and sustain adoption.

5. Strategic partnerships

Schools are leveraging external expertise (e.g., AI companies, employers, and universities) to enhance AI curriculum, capabilities, and skills training for faculty and career readiness for students.



Case studies

- **Brisbane Catholic Education**

The district secured 20,000 Microsoft 365 Copilot licenses from Microsoft (one of the largest educational deployments in the world) and partnered with leading technology firms and universities, including Willow for energy/HVAC optimization, to drive both academic and operational ROI. These partnerships have enabled mentorships, pre-apprenticeships, and real-world career pathways for students.

- **Coquitlam School District**

The district collaborated with vendors (Dell, Intel, and Lenovo) to plan for AI-ready student devices and with platform providers on secure tenancy. It engaged advisors to implement a unified data fabric and AI-based cybersecurity, aligning technology road maps with instructional goals.

6. Leadership and champion networks

Schools are combining executive ownership and strategic direction with grassroots, educator-led champion networks for sustained momentum and democratic AI decision-making.



Case studies

- **Broward County Public Schools**

The district operationalized the board-level “Broward powered by AI” vision and executive sponsorship through school-based AI ambassadors and teacher-led exemplars. Early adopters’ successes, coupled with leadership development and forensic tool audits, reinforced top-down direction with bottom-up credibility. This extended to students as well; the district engaged with students enrolled in AI Academies to vet Copilot Chat for later districtwide student adoption and to design tools to help operationalize AI (a chatbot for the community to ask questions related to website content).

- **Coquitlam School District**

A broad committee of teachers, administrators, parents, and district leaders shares ownership, while executives remove barriers to AI adoption and ensure safety first. Teacher pilots (e.g., Copilot use, agentic bots) drive peer adoption and inform system decisions.

Schools are combining executive ownership and strategic direction with grassroots, educator-led champion networks.





SECTION 2: Recommendations for IT and academic leaders

Strategic recommendations

Align AI investments with the school or district's broader strategic goals and vision

- Identify areas in which AI can significantly contribute to achieving long-term goals and objectives, maximizing the impact of AI initiatives, and supporting the organization's overall mission and vision.
- Create compelling narratives so that the case for AI becomes "Why not?" rather than "Why?"

- Focus on areas in which AI can drive the greatest value and impact, such as addressing faculty and staff burnout and attrition, learning loss and chronic absenteeism, or resource-intensive administrative or operational challenges.
- Prioritize student outcomes above all else. If you can't answer "How will this support improved student learning and well-being?", deprioritize it.

Democratize access to AI

- Democratize access to diverse AI tools by ensuring that all students, faculty, and staff, regardless of their background or area of focus, have access to AI resources. This approach promotes equity and fosters a culture of innovation across the institution.

Create a flexible and adaptive AI strategy

- Institutions should adopt an iterative approach to AI implementation, allowing for quick pivots and adjustments based on what works and what doesn't.
- Avoid rigid AI strategic plans that lock the school or the district into strict three- to five-year road maps.

Maintain a long-term perspective

- While being flexible and adaptive is important, having a long-term strategic vision for AI helps guide decision-making and ensures that AI initiatives align with broader institutional goals.

Measure impact and success; communicate wins and key learnings

- Establishing clear metrics to measure the impact of AI initiatives helps institutions understand their effectiveness and make data-driven decisions.
- Continuously collect and share compelling quantitative and qualitative data metrics that align with the priorities and goals of education leaders to earn buy-in across key stakeholder groups.

- Communicate both the wins and the key learnings and areas for improvement to earn and sustain trust.
- Create feedback loops, collecting data every five weeks to enable continuous improvement.

Allocate adequate resources for AI initiatives

- Institutions must ensure the support of AI initiatives with adequate financial and technical resources. This includes allocating sufficient budget for AI projects, investing in necessary infrastructure, and providing ongoing support to maintain and scale AI solutions.

Prepare for scale

- Don't get stuck in an infinite loop of pilots; develop a clear strategy to move from the pilot phase to full-scale implementation.

Communicate both the wins and the key learnings and areas for improvement to earn and sustain trust.



Organizational recommendations

Define clear decision-making roles and responsibilities

- Establishing clear decision-making roles and responsibilities is crucial for the successful implementation of AI projects. Institutions should define who is responsible for various aspects of AI strategy, including governance, implementation, and oversight.

Prioritize strong, clear communication

- Effective communication from leadership is crucial to ensuring that everyone within the institution understands the AI goals and vision. Clear, consistent messaging helps align efforts across departments and fosters a shared understanding of the strategic direction.
- Develop strong communication strategies, professional learning communities, and networks for knowledge sharing and the communication of school or district initiatives, policies, and other updates.

Establish a change champion network and AI community groups

- Establish change champions networks, community groups, and model schools to drive high-profile pilot projects.
- Communicate outcomes continuously through these leadership groups to build momentum and drive grassroots transformation.

Foster inclusive decision-making and stakeholder engagement

- Encourage collaboration across departments, engage all stakeholders, including those who may be skeptical of AI, and be sure to consider diverse perspectives in the strategic vision and decision-making process.

Engage the highest-level stakeholders (board/executive) early around privacy, data, people, and the business case.



- Involve stakeholders early and broadly, including the board/executives, teachers, principals, parents, clergy, and community groups.
- Engage the highest-level stakeholders (board/executive) early around privacy, data, people, and the business case.

Build internal AI capacity

- Institutions should focus on reskilling existing staff and hiring new talent with AI expertise to ensure they have the internal capabilities to support AI initiatives.
- Invest just as much in people as in technology through change management resources and support structures.
- Establish pedagogical help desks, digital communication channels with real-time support, and multiple touchpoints for continuous real-time assistance.

Encourage faculty, staff, administrators, and students to innovate and fail fast

- Schools and districts should foster a culture of innovation and continuous improvement by encouraging experimentation and allowing for quick pivots when something doesn't work.

Allow time and space for AI adoption

- Given the varying degrees of AI literacy, skills, trust, and comfort with the technology, it is essential to allow faculty, staff, and students to adopt AI at their own pace.
- Adoption should not be forced, especially in an academic setting where the focus is on learning and innovation.
- Providing time and space for individuals to explore and become comfortable with AI ensures a more organic and effective integration of the technology.

Acknowledge and address community concerns

- Create community groups that give spaces for faculty, staff, administrators, families, and students to discuss challenges, opportunities, concerns, and hopes and to share best practices and lessons learned from AI use and experiences.
- Institutions must recognize and address the concerns of the campus community regarding the adoption of AI themes, such as faculty resistance, fears of displacement, and broader cultural inertia, which are significant challenges.
- Implementing low-stakes experimentation and promoting community-led innovation are effective strategies to mitigate these fears.
- Encouraging open dialogue and clearly communicating about AI's benefits and limitations can help alleviate resistance and create a culture of trust and collaboration.

Pedagogical recommendations

Leverage AI to build teacher capacity and expand pedagogical thinking

- Leverage AI to reduce curriculum planning time while simultaneously building teacher capacity, since AI can assist in developing unit plans, lesson sequences, and learning progressions faster and more efficiently.
- Beyond using AI as simply a productivity enhancer, educators should also leverage the technology to ideate around new pedagogical or instructional approaches, since it is capable of generating ideas and suggestions that teachers might not have considered, exposing them to new approaches and strategies that enhance their teaching practices.

Shift the teacher's role from content deliverer to facilitator and relationship builder

- By using AI to handle administrative overhead and busy periods of lesson planning, teachers can reclaim their time to focus on what inspired them to enter the profession (i.e., building meaningful relationships with students and providing individualized support), thereby “getting back to real teaching” rather than being overburdened by paperwork.

Implement an AI maturity matrix for assessment transparency

- Developing a framework for appropriate student AI use — from “no AI allowed” through to “AI can help with planning,” “AI can help you write,” and “AI can complete and provide feedback” — gives students explicit clarity on allowable AI usage and prevents confusion about academic integrity expectations.

Design age-appropriate, AI-enabled learning experiences that build AI literacy and responsibility over time

- For students below the age of 13: Prioritize teacher-facilitated, scaffolded experiences (e.g., reading/numeracy coaches, guided storytelling) that emphasize curiosity, metacognition, and basic digital citizenship delivered within secure, district-managed environments and no open-ended chatbot accounts that exceed age/policy limits.

- For students aged 13 and up: Expand AI use to research, drafting, code generation, data analysis, and content creation, using approved 13+ tools in the district tenancy and with explicit instruction on verification, responsible AI, disclosure, and assignment-level “AI maturity” expectations to balance creativity with academic integrity.

Reframe AI literacy as workforce preparation and digital citizenship

- Position AI skills development not only as academic support but as essential preparation for students’ futures, recognizing that students who graduate without AI capabilities may be at a disadvantage in college and establishing careers in many industries that are already using AI tools to formulate ideas, solve problems, and enhance productivity.

Establish transparent communication with families about AI integration

- Educate parent communities not only about the risks of and guardrails around AI use but also about the benefits and pedagogical rationale, helping families understand how AI amplifies existing educational strategies and can assist them in new ways (e.g., translating school content for non-native language speakers and communicating more effectively with the school administrators) and building trust through open dialogue.

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Process and technology recommendations

Conduct a “digital renovation” to simplify IT ecosystems for AI

- Turn off legacy systems, clarify roles and permissions, tag metadata, tighten up integrations, and uplift contemporary platforms to pave the way for smoother AI implementations.

Build AI-ready infrastructure

- Investing in robust AI infrastructure is crucial to supporting the institution’s broader AI ambitions. This includes providing the necessary hardware, software, and technical resources to enable AI applications across various domains, from classrooms to research labs and administrative offices.
- Consider leveraging foundational AI models that align with the school or district’s existing infrastructure. This allows users to connect with all existing data, including email, messaging, and documents, with minimal additional integration work, while improving user experiences, AI tool performance, and security.

Ensure AI-ready data

- Establishing a robust data management strategy is essential for effective AI implementation. This includes focusing on data governance, cleaning, and integration to create reliable data sets for AI applications.
- Investing in dedicated data engineering teams ensures data quality and creates strong data pipelines that feed AI systems.

Build AI-ready processes

- Evaluate processes or educator/staff workflows to identify the areas that create the most significant administrative burden or drain the most human, technical, or financial resources and to determine AI integration opportunities.

Focus on productivity and easy gains first (staff workload reduction) before tackling more complex use cases.



- Focus on productivity and easy gains first (staff workload reduction) before tackling more complex use cases.
- Conduct the necessary business process transformation work to enable AI-driven automation. Evaluate and redesign processes to ensure they are optimized for AI integration, which can increase efficiency and effectiveness.

Invest in AI-enabled devices and computing capabilities

- Consider investing in AI PCs with confidential computing capabilities to leverage AI capabilities while protecting sensitive student and institutional data (i.e., investing in AI-ready devices with appropriate capabilities for on-device processing and compliance requirements).
- Engage with device providers to plan for generational hardware changes. Consider incremental, year-over-year investments in AI-ready devices to avoid large, unsustainable device expenditures.

Embed privacy and security by design

- Institutions must prioritize privacy and security as core principles in their AI strategy. This involves implementing robust data protection measures, ensuring compliance with relevant regulations, and designing AI systems that safeguard sensitive information from the outset.
- By embedding privacy and security into the design and development of AI solutions, institutions can build trust and protect the integrity of their data.
- Provide safe, district-approved AI products to prevent shadow AI adoption or the use of non-age-approved solutions that create privacy and security issues, particularly for younger students.



School AI initiatives around the globe



Brisbane Catholic Education (Australia)



Initiative overview

The system implemented a coordinated, ethics-led AI program to relieve teacher workload, personalize learning, and improve student well-being across 146 schools and 13,000 staff. Investment prioritized student-centered learning by focusing on increasing teacher capacity, enabling differentiated instruction, and ensuring inclusive access.



AI investment priority

The primary emphasis was on building educator capacity, personalizing learning, enabling effective governance, and driving safe, secure, and ethical AI adoption, with significant investment directed to teaching and learning use cases that streamlined faculty workflows and improved learning outcomes for students.



Implementation approach

BCE organizes AI deployment at scale through four workstreams:

- **AI Foundations:** Infrastructure, data cleanup, permissions, and security
- **AI Enablers:** Change management with school personnel and tailored training
- **Evaluation/Monitoring/Reporting:** Governance, quality assurance, impact measurement, and the collection of user feedback
- **Creative AI Lab:** Ideation and prototyping of purpose-built AI tools and agents with human oversight to test scalable solutions

Staff completed ethics training before receiving the AI tool licenses, and a “digital renovation” cleaned data, established robust system permissions, and retired legacy systems to prepare the institution’s digital ecosystem for AI.



Outcomes

The initiative reduced up to nine hours per week in administrative workload for teachers and improved student academic results by 10%–30%, with a 275% increase reported in student agency for students using AI for learning, as measured by the University of Melbourne’s New Metrics Success project, which focuses on student confidence and reduced stress during assessments. Qualitative feedback from educators indicated an improved work–life balance and the ability to spend more time personalizing learning for students.



What’s next

BCE will implement a systemwide rollout of student-facing AI tools for learners aged 13 and over. It will build scaled, purpose-built agents, moving toward a “society of agents” with human-in-the-loop oversight for strategic impact and administrative relief. BCE will continue to expand hyper-personalized learning and iterative governance updates as student tools and agentic use cases mature.



Broward County Schools (United States)



Initiative overview

A board-mandated “powered by AI” strategy linking AI to core academic goals and operational savings, anchored by the districtwide deployment of over 20,000 Microsoft 365 Copilot licenses to educators and staff, makes Broward one of the largest districts in the nation to embrace generative AI at scale. AI ambassadors in schools and targeted partnerships (e.g., Willow for energy/HVAC optimization) further support this initiative. The program prioritizes teacher productivity, leadership enablement, and high-ROI operational wins while laying the groundwork for future student-facing learning supports via vetted, monitorable, age-appropriate tools (13+) inside the district tenant. The board set a vision that focused on a foundational AI model (Copilot) that aligns with its infrastructure and data to maximize utility and security. Various AI tools were vetted by the district to ensure that vision alignment supplements the foundational model.



AI investment priority

Broward County Schools builds educator capacity and improves operational efficiency in parallel — reducing planning/communication overhead and automating clerical workflows while pursuing measurable cost reductions (energy/overtime).



Implementation approach

Executive mandate sets the direction. Each campus has designated AI ambassadors — educators who lead professional learning, support peers, and serve as liaisons between district leadership and school sites. Monthly communities of practice foster collaboration, share best practices, and accelerate adoption, ensuring consistent momentum across all schools. Vendor/resource audits twice a year and disciplined procurement mitigate security risks and prevent shadow AI, while secure tenancy and policy guardrails protect data privacy and integrity. Early student pilots (Copilot Chat) and leadership professional development/micro-credentials build AI skills, increase educator capacity, and ensure readiness for broader classroom integration. Early student pilots leverage vetted,

monitorable AI tools within the district’s secure environment, ensuring compliance with privacy and safety standards. Family communication and transparent governance build trust and support responsible use.



Outcomes

Seventy-five percent of teachers and administrators actively use Copilot, reporting an average saving of over two hours per week on lesson planning and administrative tasks. The Willow partnership has reduced districtwide energy costs by 12% in the first year, with further savings projected as AI-driven automation expands. Early classroom pilots show increased student engagement and improved writing outcomes in Grades 8–12. Targeted support ensures that multilingual learners, students with disabilities, and those in transformation schools benefit from AI resources and training. Districts nationwide are studying Broward’s model, with requests for site visits, presentations at major conferences, and ongoing collaboration with education leaders.



What’s next

Broward’s journey has not been without challenges. The district has prioritized myth-busting, supported reluctant adopters, and built feedback cycles to continuously improve implementation. Moving forward, Broward aims to scale operational ROI, tie instructional use to measurable student performance outcomes, and expand secure student access to AI tools.



Coquitlam School District (Canada)



Initiative overview

The district is executing a “go slow to go fast” program that first established AI-ready data and strengthened cybersecurity before introducing Copilot Chat for educators and agentic pilots for communication and workflow support.



AI investment priority

The district balances operational and learning priorities, emphasizing stakeholder trust and policy alignment. A central focus on building foundational data and cyber-readiness sets the stage for safe and effective AI deployment, with an emphasis on improving educator productivity first while establishing deliberate, compliant pathways to classroom personalization and assessment redesign.



Implementation approach

Methodical vendor vetting and a privacy-by-design approach to AI deployment set the foundation, and a broad educational technology committee (including teachers, administrators, parents, and district leaders) works collectively to codesign strategic direction, drive adoption, and share best practices. Sustained investment in stakeholder engagement, dedicated AI help desk support, and governance helps drive adoption, maintain trust, and prevent fragmented adoption. The district is currently planning and executing incremental annual refresh cycles to sustainably modernize student, faculty, and staff devices (e.g., NPU-compatible laptops with confidential computing capabilities).



Outcomes

The initiative has improved the district's security posture and readiness to scale AI use, with staff reporting planning/productivity gains and clearer pathways to compliant student-facing tools (13+ within tenancy). There is stronger organizational confidence and shared understanding through structured committees and monitored support channels.



What's next

Coquitlam School District will gradually expand student-facing capabilities and agentic use cases as policies and infrastructure mature, prioritizing safety, privacy, and educational value. It will continually align device strategy with on-device AI requirements to support real-time learning experiences and compliance.